dered unusable. The IMD (Indian Meteorological Department) data shows that the state received 33 per cent excess precipitation (816.4 mm against the normal of 613.8 mm) in the monsoon season, which lasted from June till August-end. Shimla got 253.3 mm of rainfall in August alone, 29 per cent more than the expected. The subsequent landslides led to the TV visuals of buildings collapsing in the city, leaving 22 dead.

THAT SINKING FEELING

The first step towards solving a problem is to acknowledge its existence. The images of collapsing buildings and caving roads have left city-dwellers in this hill state with a sinking feeling. Shimla, due to its favourable climate, was developed by the British as a 'home away from home' in an area of about 35 sq. km spread across seven hills. From 1864 onwards, it was also their summer



PTI

DAMNING NUMBERS

2,200*
homes permanently damaged

10,000
houses partially damaged

300
shops rendered unusable

33%
of Shimla city at high risk of landslides

25%
of Shimla city is sinking

10,000
buildings do not have necessary permits

14
major localities situated on a 35-70 degree gradient

*Numbers are approximate; *Source:* HP govt, NHAI, City Disaster Management Plan